

Statements

(internal, RU only; base for external reviewers; and post-tenure review)

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1 Background Information

Hopefully, I am just overthinking, and it will be quick and easy, but just in case I provide here extra background information that should be helpful if the case gets difficult.

This may be a difficult case, where my narrative differs from departmental narrative. The departmental narrative may be negative, just like my post-tenure review, attached at the end. If so, please also see my response attached at the end. This will give you more information and should clarify.

My home department, public policy and administration (DPPA), is a peculiar department. One peculiarity is emphasis on activism, community engagement, and service. Rutgers-Camden is R-2 “High Research Activity” institution—we should be mostly about research, say about 70% research, 20% teaching, 10% service, but DPPA is opposite: 70% service (mostly activism), 20% teaching, and 10% research. Another peculiarity is that there are some very strong personalities. Opinions are equally strong.¹ All I am asking for is a fair evaluation based on objective evidence. Please cross-check DPPA’s faculty opinions with the evidence available in the packet. For instance, in addition to DPPA’s opinion on my service, see my service record in CV. Also note that I am facing a cross-department friction: I led the creation of, I support, and teach in Data Science program, which is outside of my home department, DPPA. There is also departmental friction with the Prevention Science program.²

My biggest worry is that DPPA might have solicited external letters from outside of my field. There are no DPPA faculty in happiness research—but there are some who like to have opinions about it. See what the experts in happiness research say—these should be hopefully the external letters.

¹One such strong opinion is by Paul on econometrics/statistics to infer causality. Paul is not fundamentally wrong in grand scheme of things—indeed causal inference is one way to contribute—agreed; but is only one of many ways! It’s neither necessary nor sufficient for great research! And this is not the way I have chosen to contribute in my research, and I have a right to be an independent researcher.

I am contributing in different ways than causality (most social science research is not causal by the way): I have novel ideas and able to find the right data to test them—I use complex large scale datasets to study new relationships—this is my contribution as recognized by my field.

By the way, some of the greatest research out there in the very top journals like Nature or Science is not causal—it’s just a data visualization like a scatterplot, and yet it is the top of the top, cream of the crop research, that beats any other research causal or not. So don’t tell me that for a research piece to be good it has to be causal—it is simply not true. And this very top research in Nature or Science—what makes it the very top is the research idea and the right data, not causality—this is what I aspire to, and this is my research strength and direction—novel ground breaking research ideas and great data without causality.

One problem with Paul’s ideas is that he is in education area where causality is important—but my area is urbanism. Urbanism is my independent variable—it can hardly be studied in a causal way, it is an organic process in the real world—almost all research in this area, my area of research, is not causal.

Yet another point: economists (like Paul) also have it wrong that complex stats and econometrics and instrumental variables etc give you causality—no they don’t! They just get you little closer if done right, but the only way to claim causality is experiments (or sometimes quasi-experiments). Causality is not about stats or models, it is about research design. So if you want to do causality right in my area of effect of cities on happiness, you would have to assign people at random to cities and rural areas—it’s impossible.

Still, some of my research argues that the causality may be present. (But again it is impossible to know for sure without (quasi-) experiment that is not feasible in my area.) Instead, I argue directional relationship, or possibility of causality if you will, by paying attention to control variables and avoiding overcontrol bias (Golden et al. 2026), using directed effects (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Mazelis 2018) and even before-after comparison group design (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2026).

²I had great students from Prevention Science in my classes and I want to support them—now being on one dissertation committee and chairing one dissertation—but Patrice tells me I should not be doing that. Again, I don’t think I should be punished in my evaluations for supporting students from another program. We are all on the same team—DPPA could be more collegial with other programs on campus.

2 Research

I am in the field of social indicators, quality of life, wellbeing, and life satisfaction. The main journals are *Applied Research in Quality of Life* (ARIQ) and *Social Indicators Research* (SIR).³ The main academic/professional organization is International Society for Quality-of-Life Studies (ISQOLS). My field is thinner on theory than other social science, (post-)positivist, and quantitative—about patterns, relationships, and effects—but rather correlational than causal. (Quasi-)experiments are very rare, and there are more descriptions and visualizations than economics and statistics. My field is somewhere between geography, sociology, psychology, and philosophy.⁴ My interests have been broad, including politics (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2014), volunteering (Morawski et al. 2022), and agency (D'Italia and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2025).

All research is (supposed to be) new in some sense, but my research is more original/innovative than most. Many contribute only incrementally, say by slightly improving a model, adding an interaction or instrumental variables. My contribution is new ideas—human creativity is even more important in current AI age. I have creative ideas, and then able to find the right data to test them. I was the first to look at several relationships:⁵ effect of energy use on happiness (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Altman 2019), effect of social v individual religiosity on happiness across countries (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2010), and on trust in the US (Valente and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2021); effect of religiosity on creativity across space (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015b).

My main area of research has been urban-rural happiness gradient, a term coined in my early paper on the topic: “An urban-rural happiness gradient” (Berry and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2011). This line of research is not entirely new—it has been studied in a quantitative fashion in a limited way in the 70s and philosophically since antiquity—but mine are the first studies in modern times.⁶ And I have a related line of research looking at livability of places: Okulicz-Kozaryn (2013), Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2019a).

My urban-rural happiness gradient research includes careful gradient elaboration (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2017) and theory-rich Okulicz-Kozaryn and Mazelis (2018). As the research has matured, I added: generational differences (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2019b), growing-up (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2020), panel data (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023), elaborated happiness measurement (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2024), and Covid19's effect (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2026). Finally, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021) shows that urban unhappiness is common across countries.

I work with students to explore the gradient further: examined population change instead of level (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2024), and turned to non-WEIRD (Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic) societies: India (Deb and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023), Egypt (Mikhaeil et al. 2024), and Colombia (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2026).

I am at the forefront of the urban-rural happiness debate.⁷ Some may argue that happiness has little to do with public policy and administration—nothing further from the truth⁸

Near-future trajectory remains similar: mostly urban-rural happiness gradient and regional happiness, adding Latin American focus (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Martinez 2025). I plan to spend more time on grant writing to grow my research group, hire students and post-docs, and do course buy-outs.⁹

³Journal of Happiness Studies has shifted towards positive psychology and happiness economics. ARIQ is the flagship journal of ISQOLS.

⁴Geography is a notable part of it—my research intersects with geography: regions, and especially urban-rural gradient. This is a subjective description of the field, or rather sub-field, and this is where I fit. There are other sub-fields, notably positive psychology and happiness economics—they are related but different in important ways. My field is well described by its pioneer, Alex Michalos: Michalos (2014b,a).

⁵In quantitative way, focusing on and elaborating the relationship (not just listing among others or controlling for it). You will see in my many papers that the idea is indeed the first of its kind—nobody has looked at the relationship before in this way.

⁶There is a 30-40 year generational gap between mostly 70s and very few in early 80s versus my first study in 2009.

⁷For instance see the discussion in framing essay IV in Edited by Pia Heike Johansen and Fisker (2022). Likewise the literature has picked on “energy-happiness paradox”—the term that I have coined (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Altman 2019), for instance see: <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0277953625011669>, <https://link.springer.com/content/pdf/10.1007/s13132-026-03228-8.pdf>, and <https://link.springer.com/content/pdf/10.1007/s10902-025-00860-0.pdf>.

⁸See Diener (2009) and my own Okulicz-Kozaryn (2016). Likewise, there are clear policy implications of my work, for instance see (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015a, Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2014, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Golden 2017). My numerous Cities papers have dedicated takeaways for policy/practice section, e.g., see recent (Mikhaeil et al. 2024, Deb and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2022), and even if the section is missing, there are still policy implications, e.g., Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021).

⁹I already spend more time on http://pivot.proquest.com/funding_opps/ and collaborate with Todd Regn (RU-Camden grant expert) on grant ideas.

Since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, I have published 37 peer-reviewed articles, including 7 in *Cities*, a journal with impact factor (IF)=8.1, higher than the top journal in public administration in the US,¹⁰ *Public Administration Review* with IF=7.2.¹¹ Since 2017 I have also published 4 articles in *Social Indicators Research*, and 9 in *Applied Research in Quality of Life*, both leading/main journals in my field. I am also collegial and collaborative—I've coauthored with over 20 authors (Scopus), and my citations more than tripled (Scopus) or doubled (Google Scholar) since 2017.¹²

¹⁰I am in a department of public policy and administration in the US.

¹¹<https://www.scimagojr.com/journalsearch.php?q=16956&tip=sid> and <https://www.scimagojr.com/journalsearch.php?q=17167&tip=sid>

¹²And my citations on Google Scholar after having stalled for 5 years (haven't stalled on Scopus) are set to increase from 350 in 2025 to over 400 in 2026: On April 28, I'm cited at 143, it's 118th day of the year, so I have $143/118 = 1.2$ citations per day; $1.2 * 365 > 400$. Scopus: <https://www.scopus.com/authid/detail.uri?authorId=23061538900>; Google Scholar: scholar.google.com/citations?hl=en&user=pz9RYloAAAAJ. Note there also used to be my department (DPPA) metrics at researchwithrutgers.com but it appears to be down as of May 15 2026—still the underlying data are at scopus.com.

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3 Teaching

Something I have dreaded as a student, and promised myself I won't do on the other side as an instructor. Style over substance: prioritizing appearance, aesthetics, and presentation over actual quality, meaning, and functionality—it looks and sounds impressive but lacks value, real utility—just like with much of social science prose.¹³ Most instruction was unnecessarily fluffy and ornamented, often grandiose as if the goal is to put student in a sense of awe.

Now as an instructor I skip the fluff and cut to the chase—convey practical information efficiently. Usefulness/utility is the key. Learning by doing, no memorizing—for instance, students bring their own data and we apply skills and tools learned in the class to the data, no exams. When I was a student I was forced to memorize theory and formulas and read hundreds of pages of formal texts. But I wasn't taught how to use the skills and the tools. I condense the material, make it relevant, maximize utility/usefulness with minimum effort, focus on what's most important in most accessible practical hands on way.

Students appreciate my teaching style, e.g., “left a lasting impression on me and I appreciated your approach and teaching style” and “Your passion for education has inspired and impacted me in so many ways. Your commitment to helping your students grow and learn is truly admirable. Thank you for all that you do!”

I decrease instruction and increase interaction: discussions, presentations, “flip the class,”¹⁴ and extra labs in addition to the class. Such interactive social approach seems even more important in current reality: short attention span, information overload, AI, and mental health problems. We need to connect, be at ease, have good energy, and even some fun in class—it shouldn't be tedious and gruesome, at least not all of it.

It is not watering down the curriculum. I provide plenty of extra/bonus materials so that it is customized to a student, doesn't overwhelm with unnecessary stuff, but provides enough depth and individual learning path. Pleasant learning experience matters, but so do outcomes.

I want my teaching to produce results. Learning (motivation, too) is the direct result. But then comes transfer of knowledge, ability to apply that learned information. We need results either in academia or outside of it.

Since 2020, I graduated 4 PhDs, they all have a job. One is at SIPRI (Stockholm International Peace Research Institute), a think-tank ranked 11th or 31st worldwide.¹⁵ Another one at Virginia Tech and the other 2 were employed at Rutgers when graduated. My students publish. Since 2020, we have published 10 peer-reviewed papers with my students in good journals including 3 in top ranked *Cities* with Impact Factor of 8.1.

One highlight is that the skills learned in the classes not only work in the academic research, but also in the real world: “The classes I took with you are helping not only my scholarship, but my day job [...] I greatly appreciate it.” and “subject: Received a Job Offer [...] I would like to thank you for all of the guidance and knowledge during all of your data-related courses the past several semesters to help me get to the point I am at today.” and “since graduating I have continued to pursue more projects in the coding world. Some analysis projects, business models, [...] I appreciate all the help and motivation you gave me in class as it helped me to really see what I can come up with from all of the useful tools, how to plan and build on projects, and skills gained from having you as my professor.”

I try to guide students individually, in the grand scheme of things, teaching is about helping students become who they are, and everyone is little different. This is another reason for forcing less required material and making more available as bonus/extra for self-actualization. I make sure I am available and approachable for students spending extra time outside of classroom: working on papers, being accessible via zoom and in person, including when on sabbatical. Now in Spring 2026 I am on sabbatical, but I still have 4 students enrolled in my dissertation hours, and I work with other students on papers informally.

Two final points on my teaching philosophy. I support public/civic service/engagement in my teaching. All my classes encourage

¹³See <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11192-012-0937-9>.

¹⁴Work on projects and homework collaboratively in class as opposed to home as done traditionally.

¹⁵<https://thinktankalert.com/rankings> and <https://guides.library.upenn.edu/c.php?g=1035991&p=7509972>

(but not force) and give extra credit for it. And I support students even after the class in their civic endeavors—see service section. But this is not activism, it is evidence based, data driven analysis and problem-solving. It is rather positivistic “what is”, than normative “what should be,”¹⁶ I support in my teaching old fashioned critical thinking, I don’t believe classroom is a place for political indoctrination of the students. I’m (post-)positivist in my teaching—I encourage students to try to get closer to the objective truth through evidence and data. Activism and political action are better left to politicians.

I concluded my teaching philosophy, now turning to technicalities. One highlight is unusually heavy curriculum development. Since coming to Rutgers-Camden in 2012, I have taught over 10 different classes, developed from scratch most of them, including 3 courses in 2023 for our new data science program. I am updating my teaching materials each time I teach a class. Also, I mostly teach methods classes, which often receive lower evaluations.

I teach, mentor, and support students from different programs. In my home department of public policy and administration (PPA), I teach regularly in Masters of Public Administration (MPA) and MS and PhD in Public Affairs, but I also teach regularly students from MS in Data science in my always cross listed PPA courses. Usually there are also few PhDs from Prevention Science, and occasionally from other departments such as Psychology, and Criminology and Sociology.

I strive to improve my teaching: I just attended cybersecurity trainings¹⁷, and attended Instructional Design and Technology (IDT) workshop on “Crafting the Learner-Centered Syllabus” in 2024. And I quite regularly read on teaching and mentoring advice, tips and tricks on nature.com, chronicle.com, and insidehighered.com.

My feature teaching preference would be to continue with the classes I have already taught, and there are plenty of them, over 10. My strength and preference is data science classes, but also happiness class that aligns with my research. I have been also developing a new class “social indicators” that would be broader than just happiness and include topics such as trust, freedom, and meaning. This would also align with my editorial position at Social Indicators Research journal.

I am interested in teaching short courses / microcredentials. I have already taught a short GIS course¹⁸ twice, informally, for my colleagues from the department and other faculty from Arts and Sciences, and for Walter Rand Institute. But I would like to teach more often and other short courses. There is an initiative to create Microcredentials and Digital Badges—I would like to participate in it.

I am 2025 recipient of department’s Jay A Sigler award for “outstanding service and dedication to students” (awarded by students); the plaque says “this award is given to the faculty member who exhibits a commitment to student’s academic development and personal growth.”

¹⁶Similar to Network of Schools of Public Policy, Affairs, and Administration (NASPAA) competency: “to analyze, synthesize, think critically, solve problems and make decisions.”

¹⁷2026 KnowBe4 Security Awareness Training, Cybersecurity Essentials: Secure Passwords, and Introduction to IT Security Policies—these enhance my classroom teaching—most of my courses involve computer coding or data science—cybersecurity matters more there than in usual social science courses.

¹⁸<https://theaok.github.io/shortGIS/>

4 Service

My service mostly builds on and derives from my main focus and strength, research. I provide such service in two main ways: 1) to the profession/scholarly field, and 2) to students.

I review papers for journals, 4-5/mo or 48-60/year as of May 2026, including the top journals such as Journal of Personality and Social Psychology and Public Administration Review (see CV for details). Reviewing is an essential foundation of scholarly fields, and increasingly in short supply—something I can attest to as a journal editor. Since January 2024, I co-edit Social Indicators Research, the leading journal in my field of quality of life and wellbeing. My editorial philosophy is to be mentor and helper, not just gate-keeper—for instance, I am often in favor of revision prior to external review (instead of desk-reject), and I try to guide the authors, especially the junior ones.¹⁹

My research-oriented service over past 6 years 2020-2026 to students is: published 10 peer-reviewed articles with students as co-authors, supervised 9 dissertations (4 graduated; 5 in-progress), served on 6 dissertation committees, supervised 6 data science master theses, served on 2 master thesis committees in other social science, and supervised 15 independent studies. I have also led brown bag seminars and organized a workshop on academic publishing.

And I am very excited about bringing to campus an award winning²⁰ junior professor from Germany as a visiting scholar for 2 months in Fall 2026: Leonie C. Steckermeier. Leonie is a productive scholar already benefiting 2 of our doctoral students—we have monthly or so zoom meetings where we are already working on papers.

I contribute service to the campus and department. Over 2018-2022 I have lead the development of a new MS in data science and associated certificate program. This was a substantial undertaking and also somewhat challenging as the newly created programs are located outside of my home department. I have been serving since 2022 as a director for data science certificate.²¹ I am currently supervising 2 courtesy appointments as volunteer researchers in the department—they work with me on research but also helped students in my class. I frequently serve as either ad hoc chair or member on Advancement and Promotions (A&P) committee. I find this service fulfilling. I contribute to promoting quality faculty in our social sciences and I learn about my colleagues. Other committee service is enumerated in the CV.

While research-oriented service is my strength and passion, and usual campus and departmental service is my duty, I am also mindful of Rutgers-Camden public/community service/engagement mission. I agree that as a public university, we also need to engage with and provide service to the public and community. I have assisted a number of Rutgers-Camden students in their community projects over past 5 years serving as a faculty advisor for, for instance: Olorunfunmi Adebajo's internship at the Camden County Community Development Office's Homelessness Assistance Unit,²² Marlo Rossi's project at Walter Rand Institute and other projects on abortion,²³ and Ojobo Agbo Eje: "Camden Health Equity Data Visualization Initiative." ²⁴

New Jersey first, but I have been civically engaged outside of the Garden State as well. For instance, I have used my data management skills to assist with data collection and management for Ohio Business Round Table, and Michigan Economic Competitiveness Study.

In the ideal world, I would like to continue with research-oriented service. In particular, I would like to increase my research group²⁵ and co-author more with students, and ideally postdocs. Chairing dissertations and leading independent studies would be also my strength and preference. I'm happy to take on more administrative duties such as editing another journal.

¹⁹I am grateful to the editor of Journal of Applied Psychology who has guided me when I was a junior author.

²⁰Publications: <https://scholar.google.com/citations?user=xjkPIhWAAAAJ&hl=de>. Awards: ISQOLS Prize for the Best Dissertation on Quality of Life, Well being, and Happiness, 2nd prize, 2023; Best PhD Dissertation of the Faculty of Human Sciences, Dissertation Award of the Otto von Guericke University Magdeburg for outstanding research achievements in the context of the dissertation, 2022; Second prize of the Fritz Thyssen Foundation for the best social science paper in German for the article "Eine Krise der sozialen Anerkennung? Ergebnisse einer Bevölkerungsbefragung zu Alltagserfahrungen der Wert- und Geringschätzung in Deutschland.", 2019

²¹See certificates at the bottom of the page: <https://graduateschool.camden.rutgers.edu/graduate-programs>

²²News item: <https://patimes.org/from-research-to-county-strategy-how-negative-learning-shaped-camden-countys-shared-housing-innovation>

²³News item: <https://theconversation.com/abortion-laws-show-that-public-policy-doesnt-always-line-up-with-public-opinion-274699>

²⁴News item: <https://camden.rutgers.edu/news/rutgers-camdens-urban-innovation-fund-fuels-transformative-community-projects>

²⁵My past external funding includes the prestigious Polish National Science Foundation (PI), equivalent of the US Natl Science Foundation.

5 Appendix

5.1 Background Information

5.1.1 Post-tenure Patrice evaluation

Additional comments:

On the face of it this is a good record. However, there are underlying problems with Adam's performance. Specifically, Adam has been very contentious in his interactions with faculty in the department. He has threatened to sue 3 faculty members in the department. His threats have strained working relationships in the department. This makes it extremely difficult for Adam to work with faculty members at lower ranks; at the same rank, but with fewer years of service; and even full professors. Adam also threatened to hold up a PhD student's proposal over a methodological dispute with the committee chair.

Teaching: As a result of Adam's behavior, I have only one full professor that Adam has not threatened. I assigned this professor to conduct Adam's peer observation. Adam resisted allowing the faculty member to conduct the observation and delayed the process.

After multiple email exchanges, Adam finally complied with the classroom observation. However, he sent an email to the observer prior to the observation stating:

Pls don't disturb the class or interrupt or say anything in the class.

I'm happy to have this visitation in the spirit of collegiality, but please note I have concerns about your evaluations from the past as non-factual, unreasonable, and unfair.

Also please note you are not my mentor, and I'm not trying to learn anything from you.

This behavior is unacceptable. Adam needs to collaborate with the peer observers in the department. He also needs to reflect on the feedback provided and develop an action plan for improvement in areas identified by the observer.

In addition, student comments on Adam's SIRS reports indicate that his approach to teaching could be more organized. Sample comments include (see attachment for comprehensive list):

- This course needs a clear and complete syllabus as well as clear assignment instructions and an overall grading scale or rubrics for each assignment.
- Provide students with a grading rubric and clear expectations. Provide clear instructions for assignments.
- Better organize the syllabus and slides
- Needs to be better organized
- Not having a clear syllabus document and one central course page on one platform made it extremely hard to keep track of class assignments and progress
- Course needs a structured, organized Canvas site; the course website is confusing and difficult to navigate.

I recommend that Adam make an appointment with Camden IDT to get assistance with revising his syllabi and building effective Canvas sites for his courses.

I previously spoke with Adam about the following courses: GIS, Data Management, and Data Visualization. Adam has pivoted to using only Python in these courses. His rationale is as follows:

- “Python is the future of coding, QGIS may disappear”
- He can’t teach 2 different methods in the same class
- When DPPA and data science courses are cross-listed, he goes with the majority of students (e.g., data science)
- Since these courses are electives, he doesn’t see the need to make adjustments.

His syllabi use the following phrases:

- students need to have “the ability to learn basic coding”
- “if you have difficulty using a computer, this class is not for you”
- “warning if you can’t learn simple coding in Python, this class is not for you.

This language does not create a welcoming environment for DPPA students. Although, he previously used QGIS for the course GIS in the Public Sector and Stata for the MPA/Public Affairs version of Data Management, he stated he will no longer provide alternatives to Python in these courses. He also stated that Data Visualization is all Python.

This approach poses problems because it makes his courses inaccessible to some of our DPPA students. Adam seems indifferent to their needs. Lengthier comments from SIRS include:

Research Methods Fall 2021

There was absolutely no encouragement for intellectual growth and progress. If you did not come up with what the professor would have for an assignment you got an extremely poor grade with little or unhelpful feedback. Most other professors grade problem sets based on completion and effort and give helpful feedback for later, larger and graded assignments (i.e. midterms and finals).

Spending hours on complicated and unclear problem sets and reviewing them multiple times to ensure all questions were answered and then getting 3/10 grades is extremely discouraging and extremely unhelpful. This course is also the course that leads into our capstone projects but in this class we had no freedom in our research approaches and were only being taught extremely numerical, statistical, and quantitative methods with no mention of or real option for other very important research methods especially for those on the community development track.

The course materials on the professors private website were so disorganized and hard to follow. Having to look for an unclear and unorganized syllabus one place and then having to submit our assignment another place (Canvas) and then access dropbox on Sakai for feed back was extremely confusing and frustrating. Not having a clear syllabus document and one central course page on one platform made it extremely hard to keep track of class assignments and progress and to stay motivated as a person who needs structure to be successful. I have never experienced anything like this and it was extremely frustrating and stressful to navigate. It was such a shame this was the experience in this class as this is an extremely important course in our program and for our capstone.

Data Management Fall 2023

I wanted to be excited for this course, but he made it unapproachable and painful. He seemed to assume the answers to students' questions were obvious and would say "look at my notes" when students requested clarification. His notes were extremely minimal and often vague. I don't know if it occurs to him that the material he's teaching is not intuitive to people who haven't coded before. Frankly the course should not be offered to those who do not already have experience with python.

This instructor needs to learn basic pedagogy. I cannot overstate that. I never learned from a single lecture and I found office hours unhelpful as well. The instructor's communication skills and teaching skills in general make him difficult to approach. I eventually gave up on trying. Everything that I learned from this course I did on my own time by talking to graduate students in the computer science program. I have never left a review this negative before for an instructor. I am uncomfortable stating all of this, but I think it needs to be said. I would never have taken this course if I knew how it was run. I would actively discourage other students from taking this course unless it changes drastically.

Adam has been very dedicated to teaching the data science classes, but he seems indifferent to the needs of DPPA students. In addition to consulting with IDT, I recommend that Adam work with Bill Fitzgerald and other teaching mentors on the Camden Campus to address the issues highlighted above.

I would like to see Adam make a stronger contribution to teaching in his home department. Specifically, it would be helpful to have Adam take responsibility for the Regional and Economic Development course in the MS/PhD program and possibly one of the core PhD courses.

Service: Although Adam's service to the discipline and the Camden campus is good, I would like to see a stronger level of service to the department. Several DPPA faculty members have heavy service loads as program and center directors. As a result, we need Adam to take a stronger role in supporting the department. In his previous service on the Public Affairs committee with comprehensive exams, he submitted questions that had been posted online and could not be used. He appeared to put little time or effort into his work on the MS/PHD committee.

There are opportunities to take on a greater leadership role in several areas, including:

- Advising doctoral students
- Guiding dissertations and working collaboratively with other committee members
- Assisting the department with:
 - data dashboards
 - graduation rates for students,
 - data collection,
 - assisting with data from affiliated centers
- Workshops for PhD Students
- Data Mentoring

In his current role as Chair of the Awards and Events Committee, Adam needs to pay more attention to details. For example, in organizing the practice sessions for students participating in the UAA conference, he needs to clearly communicate the expectations and details of the practice sessions and coordinate multiple email reminders.

In the past, Adam has been enthusiastic about organizing brown bag presentations with graduate students. It would be helpful for him to re-engage with this practice. This aligns with his role as chair of the Awards & Events Committee. As noted above, he needs to take initiative in scheduling and communicating expectations/details of the events with faculty and graduate students.

Research: Although this is a good record, there is room for improvement in a variety of areas. In terms of research, Adam's research on cities would have more added value if he could speak to what leads to or causes unhappiness in cities. For example, is it density, diversity, or something else? What are the policy implications? In addition, it would be helpful to secure external grants and leverage internal grants/awards to fund his research, especially his Colombia project. It would also be helpful to have a clearer explanation of what his future research plans are.

5.1.2 My response to post-tenure Patrice evaluation

It's an unhelpful and negative take¹ –I have asked Patrice (dept chair) to rewrite (see appendix), but she didn't, so I respond below. Excuse me bringing up negative things, but I have not brought those up first, just responding here.

1 Difficult Department

The main criticism is I don't get along and keep on suing people. I'm actually shocked they² bring it up, they should be ashamed and keep it quiet, but since they brought it up, let me respond. What happened here is that Gloria offered \$5k for a workshop for her staff, I did the workshop, she didn't pay, so I told her I'll have to sue, then she paid.³ End of story. Why even bring this up? What did I do wrong? I'd be wrong if I didn't sue. And no hard feelings, stuff happens, let's move on. Then suing Mike: he signed merit pay evaluation that's non-factual, it said I "underperform" in "research", while I can prove I overperform (see later under research)–again looks like a clear case to me to sue. Any reasonable person would do the same.⁴ I could elaborate,⁵ but again why you even bring this up? What did you think would happen here?⁶

"Adam also threatened to hold up a PhD student's proposal over a methodological dispute with the committee chair."–yes! It was a poor dissertation. I did my job. What's strange is that Paul kicked me out of the committee, as opposed to fix the dissertation.

Teaching evaluation that I wasn't cooperating with. Paul got this idea that he is my mentor and that I need his advice. He doesn't know much about my research area and giving me bad advice (instrumental variables etc). I'm trying to steer away from him, doesn't work, he needs to force his way. Paul doesn't take it well that I don't listen to his unhelpful research advice. He retaliates by giving me bad teaching evaluation.⁷

¹Many parts are not factual and lacking objectivity. Only some parts are constructive/useful as elaborated later. Still, I find this post-tenure review useful as it hopefully results in better communication and clearer expectations.

²By "they" I mean Gloria and Patrice—as far as I can tell Gloria really runs the department, not Patrice. "On the face of it this is a good record. However, there are underlying problems with Adam's performance. Specifically, Adam has been very contentious in his interactions with faculty in the department." It is not "on the face of it", it is a good record, you didn't have anything else to pick on, so you pick on this. You confuse cause with effect: me being contentious does not cause my poor performance; rather: my good performance causes others to be contentious: they are jealous or something and keep on giving me poor evaluations like zero merit pay and then that in a vicious cycle causes me to be contentious.

³If I made things up, then she probably would not pay, but she did pay. But if there are any slightest doubts on what happened, please let me know and let's dig deeper here. And of course, it was last resort, I did ask first several times for payment.

⁴Of course, last resort, I asked several times to fix this. And then here I actually backed off for 2 reasons—I had a good conversation with the dean who convinced me it's not necessary to sue, and 2) I felt bad for Mike because I'm pretty sure it wasn't him behind this fake evaluation—it was most likely Gloria behind the scenes, Mike just signed it. But keep on pushing me and I will sue. We can go that way. It's ridiculous you even bring this up. Finally, Patrice says I threatened to sue 3 people. No. I think she means one email I sent to her, but I didn't mean her, but Mike who signed the evaluation, and effectively Gloria who was most likely behind the scenes. So it's really just about one person, Gloria.

⁵"Adam has been very contentious in his interactions with faculty"—I fit right in, everyone is. "threatened to sue 3 faculty members"—no, just one, just Gloria, but she settled so we are all good from my side. No hard feelings. Gloria also seemed to have made Mike sign poor merit pay evaluation for me, so I had to threaten lawsuit there, but it's all about Gloria behind the scenes. And Patrice misunderstood one email, it wasn't about her, but about Gloria. "His threats have strained working relationships in the department."—how? Gloria wasn't talking to me anyway—I haven't strained any relationship with Gloria—it never existed. "This makes it extremely difficult to for Adam to work with faculty members at lower ranks; at the same rank, but with fewer years of service; and even full professors."—I don't think me suing Gloria has anything to do with me working with others, especially junior folks. If anything people should appreciate me seeking justice. There's actually just one junior person, Cint, and we do get along, Clint invited me to be on his grant, we got it, and will be doing research together. It's opposite, it's most difficult to work with full professors in DPPA, not junior. Patrice blames toxic department on me—it was toxic long before I threatened to sue. Suing one person has little to do with other persons, if anything at all. And suing is a good way to seek fairness/justice, which we badly lack in DPPA—if anything I should get award, not be blamed.

⁶I guess it was meant to scare me or something or make me more docile and do what I'm told, like later under Service Patrice says I should work for free for Gloria's and Steve's centers if I understood correctly. But no, I won't be pushed around. But while I have my boundaries, at the same time, I am super friendly, I study happiness after all. Come on DPPA let's move on and let's get along, let's have a beer together:)

⁷I was trying to avoid Paul doing the evaluation—I felt like he's after me. And I had bad experience from past when he would oppose me going up to full unless I listen to his unhelpful research advice so I'd protest: "Paul is not reasonable neither fair in his evaluations," to which he responds "You are charming as always. This evaluation will happen one way or another." Why not just let it go and why being so stubborn to evaluate me? Another reason for not having Paul evaluate my teaching: he had this questionable PhD qualifying exam that was counterproductive for students, so I had at a time a political action/petition with students going on against Paul's cherished exam. I knew he was rather angry with me upending his favorite exam, so I went to Patrice and explained that there is conflict of interest: I am rallying up students against Paul's favorite exam, and you have Paul evaluate my teaching. Patrice brushed it off. Patrice could have done evaluation herself, could have chosen another associate professor. Actually I did find a great evaluator myself, Bill Fitzgerald from Teaching Matters—Bill did agree to do the evaluation. Again, no, it had to be Paul. Yet another reason I gave to Patrice: the class I was teaching was outside of Paul's expertise, and you'll see in attached evaluation in appendix that Paul didn't understand much of the class. Last but not least, I wouldn't be sure 100% from all of this that Paul was indeed retaliating. But I did confront him after evaluation, I met him in person and told him I felt it was like retaliation, that you were going after me. His face went red. I actually didn't fully expect it! I thought maybe I was overthinking and being paranoid. I mean we're all human, Paul is a good person in general I guess, but come on, really? This is the kind of stuff we have going on in DPPA.

2 Teaching

"Adam has been very dedicated to teaching the data science classes, but he seems indifferent to the needs of DPPA students."—fundamentally, there is a cross-department friction here: Patrice does not want me to teach data science students. But data science is my strength and we have a new data science program that I am supporting—I don't think I should be penalized for supporting another program. Importantly, the good news now for even most coding-averse DPPA students is AI that can write the code for them, so it should be all fixed (as of 2025 seems to be great), but let's revisit in some time what's best for students.

In teaching section Patrice cherry picks negative student evaluations out of mostly positive ones. To be sure, I did take those into account long time ago when I saw them—fixed up Canvas, organized better. I do take teaching seriously.

And I strive to improve my teaching—no need for Patrice to tell me that. For instance, I just attended cybersecurity training⁸, and attended Instructional Design and Technology (IDT) workshop on "Crafting the Learner-Centered Syllabus" in 2024. And I quite regularly read on teaching and mentoring advice, tips and tricks on [nature.com](https://www.nature.com), [chronicle.com](https://www.chronicle.com), and [insidehighered.com](https://www.insidehighered.com).

3 Service

"I would like to see a stronger level of service to the department"—I heard that 3 years ago when department denied support for my promotion due to poor departmental service⁹—so I asked what else can I do for the department. I did everything I was asked to do, and more, I did extra things I wasn't asked (see CV for my service details), in fact I went to Patrice every semester to check on service. Last year, on 2025-10-20 Mon, I met with Patrice, I went over my service from my CV, and she did say "the service is ok."¹⁰ No comments.

Just briefly to respond to the things Patrice says I should be doing. "There are opportunities to take on a greater leadership role in several areas, including:"

- "Advising doctoral students" "Guiding dissertations and working collaboratively with other committee members"—that's funny! I supervise 5. The departmental recommendation is 3. So there is no thanks for going above and beyond, and apparently I don't do enough. In addition I am supervising master theses in Data Science, and I do many independent studies—in fact I think I'm doing more than anybody else in the department here. Over past 6 years 2020-2026, supervised 9 dissertations (4 graduated; 5 in-progress), served on 6 dissertation committees, supervised 6 data science master theses, served on 2 master thesis committees in other social sciences, and supervised 15 independent studies.
- "Assisting the department with: data dashboards, graduation rates for students, data collection"—that sounds like institutional research, not a part of my job description.
- "assisting with data from affiliated centers"—Patrice seems to ask that I work for Gloria's and Steve's centers apparently for free. I don't believe it's in my job description. However, I'm always happy to do paid consulting. (Gloria would have to pay upfront to avoid problems from the past).
- "Workshops for PhD Students"—I do those occasionally, e.g., "Publish or Perish—how to publish" and did GIS workshop. I was doing regularly brown bags, but Patrice told me we don't need them, now apparently she changed her mind, so happy to do those again.
- "Data Mentoring"—I don't know what that means, I guess that's what I do in my classes and with students that I advise, I don't see where else I should be doing it.

⁸2026 KnowBe4 Security Awareness Training, Cybersecurity Essentials: Secure Passwords, and Introduction to IT Security Policies—these enhance my classroom teaching—most of my courses involve computer coding or data science—cybersecurity matters more there than in usual social science courses.

⁹Which was also surprising at the time as I was doing what I was asked to do. But I thought then maybe I need to be more pro-active, don't wait to be told what to do, and do extra things. I also promised myself that this won't happen again, and I focused on service over past 3 years (see CV) at the cost to my research—I was devastated my research has suffered (research is my main thing, the reason I'm in academia) but I thought at least I'm sure I have fixed my service. But here we go again!

¹⁰I am 100% sure: I wrote it down along with the date.

"he submitted questions that had been posted online and could not be used."—Paul did the same, i.e., used published papers in exam questions. I might have occasionally used/re-used questions from the past—my understanding was that it was fine as long as it is not all of the questions and not from prior year. "He appeared to put little time or effort into his work on the MS/PHD committee."—I am efficient and productive.

4 Research

My favorite section. "There is room for improvement"—wow. I was asked not to compare and not to be personal, so no names, just overall department stats.

Research impact or visibility is commonly measured with citations, and I am the most cited person in the department, by large margin. As of May 11 2026, I'm cited exactly 2x the second best person in the department this year.

Quantity of research output is measured at [researchwithrutgers.com](https://www.researchwithrutgers.com) (appears to be down as of May 15 2026, but the underlying data are at scopus.com)—both at research units/department level and employee level. The department (research unit: Graduate School, Camden: Public Policy and Administration) has 10 employees.¹¹ Over the years 2019-2022¹² the 10 employees of the department have produced 37 research outputs,¹³ out of which 17 were mine,¹⁴ i.e., I have produced about half of the 10 person unit's output.¹⁵

2023-May 2026, the department has produced 33 outputs, out of which 13 are mine—I have been burdened with unfair amount of service over past 3 years, but still I have produced 40% of the department's output.

Visibility (and arguably quality and competitiveness) of the research output can be measured as Impact Factor (IF). I'm pretty sure there are only 2 people in this 10-person department that consistently publish in high impact journals, I am one of them. Since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, I have published 37 peer-reviewed articles, including 7 in *Cities*, a journal with impact factor (IF)=8.1.

And the department chair tells me "there is room for improvement." I would refrain from further comments to end it on a positive note.

5 Conclusion and Discussion

It's time for new blood and new leadership in DPPA. I would like to volunteer to be a department chair. This department can do well.¹⁶

Or at least let's capitalize on my research strengths. I see myself as a research leader in the department—I'm not only productive myself in research, but also I lead the students in research. My students publish.¹⁷ I would like take on more leadership in research, for instance, I would like to take students to ISQOLS conference.¹⁸ I could also take on more administrative roles, for instance take the lead of the PhD program (if we can agree to focus more on science and less on activism).

I offer many more ideas in the section below.

¹¹<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/organisations/public-policy-and-administration/persons/>

¹²I took these from my merit pay which I wrote Nov15 2023.

¹³<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/organisations/public-policy-and-administration/publications>

¹⁴<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/persons/adam-okulicz-kozaryn/publications/>

¹⁵Of course, the measure is crude and simplistic as it doesn't differentiate research output's length and quality. Still, it is remarkable that over 4 years one person has produced as much as other 9 people. And on quality, too, as measured by Impact Factor of journals, there are only 2 people in the department publishing in high impact journals, I am one of them.

¹⁶Let's have more democracy, where non-full professors' voices are heard. Let's make sure people can grow, and pursue their own path.

We have these rigid structures both historical and current. Historical: someone decided probably 20-50 years ago we need certain class in core as requirements such as regional economic development, the person teaching that is long gone, the requirement still exists. Current: we have very rigid military-like structure, there is one person at the top, then 3 more in a 'Politburo'-like structure and they are telling the rest what to do. Let's get rid of that and have democracy and capitalize on people's strengths and individual paths.

For instance, let's capitalize on my data science strength in teaching—we already started doing that and let's continue. I'm better fit to teach data science than regional economic development or quantitative methods that should be modernized and redesigned towards data science. I can make the case that data science (and Python, not Qgis or Stata) is the future and benefits our students. I am mindful of the fact that some DPPA students have struggled in the past, but now with AI that should not be a problem anymore.

¹⁷Since 2020, we have published 10 peer-reviewed papers with my students in good journals including 3 in top ranked *Cities* with Impact Factor of 8.1. I co-edit *Social Indicators Research*—this also benefits our students—I have mentored 2 students to publish in the journal, and I involve the students also in the reviewing process for the journal.

¹⁸We should not prioritize the UAA conference—our research strengths do not lie there.

6 Questions to Patrice and Answers

- The evaluation is mostly unhelpful and unproductive—it's supposed to be about research/teaching/service and forward looking. Instead you bring up conflicts from the past. Look, I am trying to de-escalate here and get along, let's just drop that part about past conflicts and misunderstandings.

In addition your write-up puts DPPA in bad light, and some other people, too. If you don't drop the part about conflicts, then I have to respond to that as it goes on my file and it's a vicious cycle. I think you miss important things here, you put dirt not just on me, but also on department, Gloria and Paul and Mike, as you force me to respond and elaborate on what really happened here.

A: Patrice wants to keep that.

- Who wrote it? Gloria? Someone else? Just you or with input from someone?¹⁹ A: She wrote this.
- You understand you keep on writing non-factual/fake evaluations like my merit pay and this one? A: No response.
- Need examples? Service you said last year was ok, now you flipped to saying I need more. A: "You service to campus is very good, to discipline is strong." But maintain that to the department is not good.
- Can we agree to have factual, evidence-based evaluations?²⁰ A: Agreed we will be putting things in writing.
- I am also happy to be consulted and asked questions ahead of the evaluation, help out if anything is unclear. A: ""
- Can you also please respect conflict of interest for the future? Even perceived or potential only? Like with Paul's teaching evaluation. A: Couldn't agree here. Don't see conflict of interest there.
- You are not a serious person—you did say my service was good, now you flipped. Do you remember you did say, on 2025-10-20 Mon: "the service is ok"?²¹²² A: Patrice doesn't remember. We agreed going forward putting things in writing will be helpful.
- I've been given service for 14 years I'm here and I always agreed to everything, don't you think it is time for some initiative from my side and some flexibility? A: ""
- We should capitalize on my research strengths, I see myself as a research leader in the department, leading students, and publishing with them. (I am not a data guy to run stats for people.) A: ""
- For instance, I cannot do UAA pre-presentations, I don't know what this conference is about, but I am happy to do ISQOLS pre-presentations, that's where our research strength is. What do you think? A: Not sure if that's the best way.
- I can also do brown-bags, great you do not oppose to these anymore? A: Ok great agreed here, we will do brown bags.
- I don't think we need events/awards committee—it doesn't do much good, and what good it does is handled by Mike, you, and Lisa anyway. My role doesn't do much, just bureaucracy and unnecessary meetings. I was ok to chair it but can you please remove me from this committee, at least for a year?²³ A: "" Still I am doing a lot outside of the department, not for the department.
- Processing student data and doing stats for the dept is not a part of my job, that's institutional research. Agreed? A: ""

A: Doing more than 5 dissertations that I am doing now would not be good. A: 4 dissertation committee memberships is enough.

¹⁹I doesn't sound like Patrice.

²⁰This is at the core of the disagreement and conflict: evaluations are not factual.

²¹I am 100% sure I wrote it down along with the date.

²²Now you just said: ""I would like to see a stronger level of service to the department," that is, I do not do enough for the dept.

²³Importantly, now I just have too much other meaningful/important service: dissertations, MS theses, independent studies, visiting professor, AP committee, etc—see CV.

- You seem to be suggesting I do unpaid data work for Gloria's and Steve's centers? I don't believe it's in my job description either? A: ""
- I am happy to do paid data consulting. Or be part of grants, like with Clint. Don't you think it is a good idea? A: ""
- What workshops for PhDs do you have in mind (beyond brown bags)? For instance, I could do workshops on publishing, GIS, and maybe especially "finding the right data" may be most useful? Can we find some money for those in the budget? We could also perhaps split with other departments? A: ""
- I can do more administrative work for the department. Can I be a chair? A: "" Patrice was laughing.
- I can also head PhD? Can we agree to focus on science, not activism? A: ""
- Teaching—we have AI, now even least able people can write code, so Python is actually easier than Stata or Qgis, lets revisit next year how it goes? A: ""
- Do you want me to make the case for Python? A: ""
- Also, can we redesign PhD towards data science, so it fits better our faculty? For instance, let's drop Regional Economic Development and make a data science class required? A: ""

[in general, let's give people some voice, and re-design existing structures around current people—for instance Regional Economic Development was probably put there 20 years ago when we had someone specializing in that, let's redesign now towards data science]

- We can also redesign QM1 and QM2 towards data science and can I teach those? Or replace QM1 with data visualization at least? A: ""
- Canvas and syllabi were made perfectly clear long time ago, anything else? Want to have a look if anything missing there? You can get back with me later. A: ""
- Research-Did you read my papers? Which ones? A: Patrice read some of my research.
- Or Paul wrote this part of evaluation? He didn't read my papers either—they say what affects happiness in cities, and there are policy implications. Or do I miss something? A: ""
- I think what happened here, is that Paul or you do not like the quality of my research? Or find some elements missing? A: ""
- But you are NOT experts in my area, that's why we use external reviewers who are experts. Are you positioned well to evaluate my research? Why would you think so? A: ""
- Do you publish on happiness? Do you publish in similar journals? A: ""
- Why would you read my research, and not just use scientometrics? A: ""
- Do I underperform on any scientometrics? A: ""
- Do I have a right to conduct independent research? A: ""
- Isn't telling me to change my research, for instance Paul was pushing for instrumental variables, invading my right to academic freedom? A: ""
- Can I make it clear that I do not welcome Paul's research advice? A: ""
- How come my research is not evaluated as exceeding expectations? What are the expectations? A: ""
- What is missing? Is the topic bad? Or bad journals? A: ""

7 Appendix: asked Patrice to rewrite

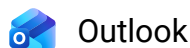
Technically, Patrice did submit revised evaluation, but practically it is about the same, see next section.

I have even asked the other 2 full professors, Paul and Gloria, to focus on research/teaching/service as opposed to department politics:

Dear Paul/Gloria,

just wanted to bring your attention to Patrice draft of my post-tenure review—while it's supposed to be about research/teaching/service and forward looking, unfortunately, she brings up there unhelpful and negative things from past like our past disagreements—I asked her to remove those to no avail, maybe you could talk to her—those reflect bad on DPPA, it puts everyone in bad light. I am trying to de-escalate here, so we can put past misunderstandings behind and work together for the good of the department and students.

cheers adam



Re: Post Tenure Review

From Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <ao264@camden.rutgers.edu>

Date Thu 5/14/2026 7:28 PM

To Patrice Mareschal <marescha@camden.rutgers.edu>

by the way, speaking of AI wonders here's an AI summary:

Here's a clear, concise summary of your email [Re: Post Tenure Review](#):

Purpose

You propose a call with Patrice Mareschal and outline how to revise and frame your post-tenure review discussion.

Main Points**1. Tone and Strategy**

- Suggest removing contentious issues (lawsuits, Paul's evaluation).
- Recommend a more constructive, de-escalated message emphasizing respectful communication for the benefit of students and the department.

2. Teaching

- Defend the value of teaching Python to DPPA students.
- Argue it is highly practical (students using it in jobs, research).
- Emphasize that AI tools make Python accessible.
- Offer to provide evidence and additional support (labs, extra time).

3. Service

- Push back on claims of insufficient service.
- State that your contributions may be undercounted.
- Highlight heavy workload (multiple dissertations, mentoring, visiting faculty support).
- Propose new initiatives (data workshops, brown bags, research gatherings, possibly rethinking PhD structure).

4. Research

- Express strong frustration that your research is undervalued.
- Emphasize both quantity and quality (publications, citations, editorial board).
- Position yourself as a research leader who collaborates with students.

5. Conflict with Paul (Research Philosophy)

- Strongly object to pressure to pursue causal methods.
- Assert your right to independent research direction.
- Argue that:
 - Causality is only one valid approach.
 - Your field (urbanism) does not typically use causal designs.
 - Many top publications rely on ideas and data rather than causal methods.
- Emphasize that evaluation should rely on external reviewers and field standards, not internal opinions outside the field.

6. Overall Ask

- Request a fair evaluation grounded in:
 - External review letters
 - Field-specific standards
 - Recognized metrics (impact, journals, citations)

Tone

- Candid, detailed, and at times emotional
 - Mix of conciliatory intent (toward Patrice) and strong defense (against Paul's critique)
-

From: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <ao264@camden.rutgers.edu>

Sent: Thursday, May 14, 2026 7:21 PM

To: Patrice Mareschal <marescha@camden.rutgers.edu>

Subject: Re: Post Tenure Review

hi Patrice, sorry about the delay, blocked off couple days for research and tenure packet without email, how's tomorrow (fri)? pick a time

in a nutshell:

-i think we should drop the part about lawsuits and paul's teaching evaluation; instead we can de-escalate, and say something constructive and productive along these lines: "despite past conflicts and miscommunications, we have agreed for friendly and respectful communication for the benefit of students and department"—i mean it and i will make every effort to do it

-in teaching: i am NOT indifferent to DPPA students (v data science), happy to explain more, but real quick: many DPPA students benefit greatly from python, notably erick watt udogu, not just for his research, but notably for his administrative job--he's using it every day and contributes greatly to the campus with Python from my class; shirley and benito just registered for more python classes, etc etc; importantly, now there is AI built-in, one does not need to write the code, just ask AI to do it, it makes it easier immensely, it does wonders—i strongly believe it makes Python very accessible, as much as stata and qgis if not more, and looking into the future we would make our students a disservice if we dont teach them the latest and greatest tools; im happy to provide evidence and make the case, just real quick here is an accesible read: <https://www.theatlantic.com/science/archive/2018/04/the-scientific-paper-is-obsolete/556676/> ; i can also do extra labs and spend extra time outside of classroom to get students up to the speed!

-service--i think you have missed many service items from my cv; i think it is unfair to say i have not been doing enough, i don't ask you to say it's excellent, but i think it was at least ok or good enough, lets

discuss more, and sure there are couple things more i would like to do; i think one problem and frustration was that i was just assigned service, but i have couple great ideas for service that i would like to do and i think would benefit department greatly, eg 'how to find data' workshops or phds, regular brown bags, semi-informal research get-togethers like faculty-student mixer, but about research—we could go to nuanced and talk about research over coffee; last but not least i'd be happy to run phd if we can agree to drop exams (eg prevention science doesn't have them) and say have a publishable paper requirement or at least limit these exams (if paul wants to administer them fine); i see myself as research leader—I'm not only very productive in research myself but also lead students—over past 6 years published 10 papers with students including 3 in high impact journals—I involve students in reviewing papers for social indicators research, i mentored 2 students to publish in social indicators research—I think we should capitalize more on my research strengths

-research--this has been maybe the source of my greatest frustration over past few years, i feel that for some reason the department doesn't appreciate my research contributions; i don't think it's just quantity, but also quality!--i consistently publish in quality high impact journals, i've been elected to the editorial board for social indicators research, my work is highly cited, etc etc

per paul—may skip this--lots of ideas here and rambling a bit, but in case you wanted more info here: i might have over-reacted slightly, but the thing is he's NOT in my research area, and however well-intentioned his advice might have been, it was NOT helpful; i have a right to do independent research—paul has no right to tell me what kind of research i need to do, i think it stems from the fact that i have been his student 20 years ago, but i am not anymore; we don't really do causality in my area of research, we do not do experiments (neither does paul! if you haven't done it yourself don't ask others--this is a fun fact that got lost somewhere--my research is more methodologically advanced than his--i'm using regressions, he just has tables of descriptive statistics); he is always pushing me to do instrumental variables, it's not a great idea, it may work out, maybe at some point, but saying or implying i have to do it to get his vote to be promoted is not right—I welcome comments and collegiality, but he is really pushing it and forcing it—I do not welcome such advice, i want to make this clear

paul is not fundamentally wrong in grand scheme of things—indeed causality is one way to contribute—agreed; but is **just one of many ways!** it's neither necessary nor sufficient for great research!!; and this is not the way i have chosen to contribute in my research, and i have a right to be an independent researcher; i may do causality at some point if i decide so, and it is my decision, not his; his right is to vote however he wants on my promotion, but again i do not welcome paul pushing on me his causality advice

i am contributing in different ways than causality (most social science research is not causal by the way!); i have novel ideas and able to find the right data to test them—I use complex large scale datasets to study new relationships—this is my contribution as recognized by my field; then someone may come and maybe do causal research building on my work and that would be her contribution, but i have contributed, too—if i haven't i wouldn't be publishing in high impact journals, but i do

by the way some of the greatest research out there in the very top journals like nature or science is NOT causal, it's just a data visualization like a scatterplot, and yet it is the top of the top, cream of the crop research, that beats any other research causal or not; so don't tell me that for a research piece to be good it has to be causal—it is simply not true! it just frustrates me a ton, paul seems to really believe what he is saying, but he is just wrong here, and doesn't even want to be open to changing his mind; and this very top research in nature or science—what makes it the very top is the research idea and the right data NOT causality, this is what i aspire to, and this is my research strength and direction—novel ground

breaking research ideas and great data WITHOUT causality; if paul thinks nature or science papers are not good because they are not causal, i dont know what to say

paul himself has never done any causal research and he is a full professor, don't tell me to do something you havent done yourself, especially regarding promotion--again sure we can one day sit together have a coffee and do some causal research at some point but i strongly dont believe this is a requirement for promotion; one problem with paul's ideas is that he is in education area where causality is important; my area is urbanism;

urbanism is my independent variable--it can hardly be studied in a causal way, it is an organic process in the real world, almost all research in this area, my area of research, is not causal

yet another point, last one, i could go on for more believe me, but for sake of time, economists (like paul) also have it wrong that complex stats and econometrics and instrumental variables etc give you causality; no they don't! they just get you little closer if done right, but the only way to claim causality is experiments or quasi experiments; causality is not about stats or models, it is about research design; so if you want to do causality right in my area of effect of cities on happiness, you would have to assign people at random to cities and rural areas—it's impossible it doesnt make any sense

anyway, lets agree to disagree here, and i am only asking you to facilitate a fair evaluation and just please read the external letters from my field and see what the experts in my field say

and i think in general the role of full professors in the dept is just to read external letters of experts in my field, not read the research itself; you can also look at metrics such as impact factors, journal rankings, citations, etc; but it is problematic to evaluate research in not one's area—paul doesn't study happiness neither publish in journals that i publish, so he doesnt know standards of my field—thats why we have external reviewers

i think i know what i am saying here i've been on like 10 A&P cases, i have chaired like 5 cases—we don't force our research ideas on the candidate, don't read the research and evaluate it, because it is not our field! if paul was studying effect of urban-rural gradient on happiness and published in cities, social indicators research and applied research in quality of life, we would understand each other better; but he was my stats professor 20 years ago and he still thinks he is

cheers and talk soon!

From: Patrice Mareschal <marescha@camden.rutgers.edu>

Sent: Sunday, May 10, 2026 2:43 PM

To: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <ao264@camden.rutgers.edu>

Subject: Re: Post Tenure Review

Hi Adam,

Let's schedule a time this week to discuss the review process and my comments . I am available:

- Monday, May 11, 3:30pm-5:00pm
- Tuesday, May 12, 10:00am-11:00am
- Wednesday, May 13, 3:30pm-5:00pm

8 Appendix: Original and Rewritten Patrice's evaluation

Again, technically, Patrice did submit revised evaluation, but practically it is about the same. My comments respond to the original version.

8.1 Rewritten

Additional comments for Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn:

On the face of it this is a good record. However, there are underlying problems with Adam's performance. Specifically, Adam has been very contentious in his interactions with faculty in the department. He has threatened to sue 3 faculty members in the department. His threats have strained working relationships in the department. This makes it extremely difficult for Adam to work with faculty members at lower ranks; at the same rank, but with fewer years of service; and even full professors. Adam also threatened to hold up a PhD student's proposal over a methodological dispute with the committee chair.

Although Adam has requested that the threatened lawsuits not be mentioned here, it is important to document the impact that this behavior has on the functioning of the department.

Teaching: As a result of Adam's behavior, I have only one full professor that Adam has not threatened. I assigned this professor to conduct Adam's peer observation. Adam resisted allowing the faculty member to conduct the observation and delayed the process.

After multiple email exchanges, Adam finally complied with the classroom observation. However, he sent an email to the observer prior to the observation stating:

Pls don't disturb the class or interrupt or say anything in the class.

I'm happy to have this visitation in the spirit of collegiality, but please note I have concerns about your evaluations from the past as non-factual, unreasonable, and unfair.

Also please note you are not my mentor, and I'm not trying to learn anything from you.

After the observation, the peer observer provided constructive feedback (although later than anticipated) and Adam argued with and rejected nearly every recommendation that was made.

This behavior is unacceptable. Adam needs to collaborate with the peer observers in the department. He also needs to reflect on the feedback provided and develop an action plan for improvement in areas identified by the observer.

In addition, student comments on Adam's SIRS reports indicate that his approach to teaching could be more organized. Sample comments include (see attachment for comprehensive list):

- This course needs a clear and complete syllabus as well as clear assignment instructions and an overall grading scale or rubrics for each assignment.
- Provide students with a grading rubric and clear expectations. Provide clear instructions for assignments.

- Better organize the syllabus and slides
- Needs to be better organized
- Not having a clear syllabus document and one central course page on one platform made it extremely hard to keep track of class assignments and progress
- Course needs a structured, organized Canvas site; the course website is confusing and difficult to navigate.
- This instructor needs to learn basic pedagogy.

I recommend that Adam make an appointment with Camden IDT to get assistance with revising his syllabi and building effective Canvas sites for his courses. Adam did state that previously made some revisions to his Canvas sites such as including specific due dates, I am currently unable to view them. Based on the student comments, I strongly advise him to meet with IDT.

I previously spoke with Adam about the following courses: GIS, Data Management, and Data Visualization. Adam has pivoted to using only Python in these courses. His rationale is as follows:

- “Python is the future of coding, QGIS may disappear”
- He can’t teach 2 different methods in the same class
- When DPPA and data science courses are cross-listed, he goes with the majority of students (e.g., data science)
- Since these courses are electives, he doesn’t see the need to make adjustments.

His syllabi use the following phrases:

- students need to have “the ability to learn basic coding”
- “if you have difficulty using a computer, this class is not for you”
- “warning if you can’t learn simple coding in Python, this class is not for you.”

This language does not create a welcoming environment for DPPA students. Although, he previously used QGIS for the course GIS in the Public Sector and Stata for the MPA/Public Affairs version of Data Management, he stated he will no longer provide alternatives to Python in these courses. He also stated that Data Visualization is all Python.

This approach poses problems because it makes his courses inaccessible to some of our DPPA students. Adam’s response to our discussion was that AI now writes and debugs code, so it is actually easier for students because they don’t have to learn how to code.

Adam has been very dedicated to teaching the data science classes, but he seems less attentive to the needs of DPPA students. In our discussion, Adam noted that he added the phrases above such as “warning if you can’t learn simple coding in Python, this class is not for you” in response to the comments that students made in SIRS.

In addition to consulting with IDT, I recommend that Adam work with Bill Fitzgerald and other teaching mentors on the Camden Campus to address the issues highlighted above. We discussed that consulting with IDT and Bill Fitzgerald does not eliminate the need for DPPA faculty to conduct peer observations of teaching.

I would like to see Adam make a stronger contribution to teaching in his home department. Specifically, it would be helpful to have Adam take responsibility for the Regional and Economic Development course in the MS/PhD program and possibly one of the core PhD courses. However, during our discussion Adam indicated that he does not want to teach this course. He only wants to teach courses related to happiness/wellbeing and data. He also recommended that the PA curriculum be revised to fit current faculty members' interests.

We discussed the number of dissertations Adam is currently chairing (4), and I advised against taking a on a 5th dissertation in Prevention Science.

Service: Although Adam's service to the discipline and the Camden campus is good, I would like to see a stronger level of service to the department. Several DPPA faculty members have heavy service loads as program and center directors. As a result, we need Adam to take a stronger role in supporting the department.

In his previous service on the Public Affairs committee with comprehensive exams, he submitted questions that had been posted online and could not be used. He appeared to put little time or effort into his work on the MS/PHD committee and informed the interim director that his approach to committee work was based on a book titled, *The Subtle Art of Not Giving a F**K*.

Adam mentioned that he does not currently want to serve on the MS-PHD committee and he won't get involved with it unless the requirement for comprehensive exams is eliminated.

There are opportunities for Adam to take on a greater leadership role in several areas, including:

- Assisting the department with:
 - data dashboards
 - graduation rates for students,
 - data collection,
 - assisting with data from affiliated centers
- Data Mentoring
- Workshops for PhD Students

Adam stated that these activities are not part of his job description and he is not willing to do this unless he is given additional pay through a grant or contract. He did state that he would be willing to offer 1 workshop per AY (limited to 1-2 hours).

In his current role as Chair of the Awards and Events Committee, Adam needs to pay more attention to details. For example, in organizing the practice sessions for students participating in the UAA conference, he needs to clearly communicate the expectations and details of the practice sessions and coordinate multiple email reminders.

In the past, Adam has been enthusiastic about organizing brown bag presentations with graduate students. It would be helpful for him to re-engage with this practice. This aligns with his role as chair of the Awards & Events Committee. As noted above, he needs to take initiative in scheduling and communicating expectations/details of the events with faculty and graduate students. However, Adam stated that he no longer plans to chair or serve on the Awards and Events committee.

Research: Adam stated that his strength is in research, and he believes this is his contribution to the department. He stated that he may consider taking on editorship of a second journal. Adam became argumentative during this part of the discussion and rejected any input.

Conclusion: Adam complained that the post-tenure review is supposed to be forward-looking. I explained that the document is both a review of previous actions since being granted tenure (or in the 5 years preceding the most recent review) and a description of future plans.

Going forward, it would be helpful for Adam to work on establishing more collaborative relationships with faculty in the DPPA. He also needs to strengthen his service to the department. It was not feasible for Adam to take on additional DPPA committee service in AY 2025-2026 due to his spring 2026 sabbatical that would take him away from campus from mid-December 2025 through mid-to-late August 2026.

Adam indicated that might be willing to serve as the Public Affairs program director and chair the MS/PHD committee in a year or so. If he intends to transition into this role, he should begin serving on the MS/PHD committee in AY 2026-2027 so he can become more knowledgeable about the policies, procedures, and roles of the program director.

He also mentioned that he might be willing to serve as the department chair in a year or so. High-quality, successful service as a program director, including participation in the graduate program directors' meetings, could be a steppingstone to the department chair role. If Adam is serious about taking on these leadership roles, I recommend that he participate in the Associate Provost for Faculty Affairs' leadership workshop once he becomes program director.

8.2 Original

Additional comments:

On the face of it this is a good record. However, there are underlying problems with Adam's performance. Specifically, Adam has been very contentious in his interactions with faculty in the department. He has threatened to sue 3 faculty members in the department. His threats have strained working relationships in the department. This makes it extremely difficult for Adam to work with faculty members at lower ranks; at the same rank, but with fewer years of service; and even full professors. Adam also threatened to hold up a PhD student's proposal over a methodological dispute with the committee chair.

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After multiple email exchanges, Adam finally complied with the classroom observation. However, he sent an email to the observer prior to the observation stating:

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Also please note you are not my mentor, and I'm not trying to learn anything from you.

This behavior is unacceptable. Adam needs to collaborate with the peer observers in the department. He also needs to reflect on the feedback provided and develop an action plan for improvement in areas identified by the observer.

In addition, student comments on Adam's SIRS reports indicate that his approach to teaching could be more organized. Sample comments include (see attachment for comprehensive list):

- This course needs a clear and complete syllabus as well as clear assignment instructions and an overall grading scale or rubrics for each assignment.
- Provide students with a grading rubric and clear expectations. Provide clear instructions for assignments.
- Better organize the syllabus and slides
- Needs to be better organized
- Not having a clear syllabus document and one central course page on one platform made it extremely hard to keep track of class assignments and progress
- Course needs a structured, organized Canvas site; the course website is confusing and difficult to navigate.

I recommend that Adam make an appointment with Camden IDT to get assistance with revising his syllabi and building effective Canvas sites for his courses.

I previously spoke with Adam about the following courses: GIS, Data Management, and Data Visualization. Adam has pivoted to using only Python in these courses. His rationale is as follows:

- “Python is the future of coding, QGIS may disappear”
- He can’t teach 2 different methods in the same class
- When DPPA and data science courses are cross-listed, he goes with the majority of students (e.g., data science)
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His syllabi use the following phrases:

- students need to have “the ability to learn basic coding”
- “if you have difficulty using a computer, this class is not for you”
- “warning if you can’t learn simple coding in Python, this class is not for you.

This language does not create a welcoming environment for DPPA students. Although, he previously used QGIS for the course GIS in the Public Sector and Stata for the MPA/Public Affairs version of Data Management, he stated he will no longer provide alternatives to Python in these courses. He also stated that Data Visualization is all Python.

This approach poses problems because it makes his courses inaccessible to some of our DPPA students. Adam seems indifferent to their needs. Lengthier comments from SIRS include:

Research Methods Fall 2021

There was absolutely no encouragement for intellectual growth and progress. If you did not come up with what the professor would have for an assignment you got an extremely poor grade with little or unhelpful feedback. Most other professors grade problem sets based on completion and effort and give helpful feedback for later, larger and graded assignments (i.e. midterms and finals).

Spending hours on complicated and unclear problem sets and reviewing them multiple times to ensure all questions were answered and then getting 3/10 grades is extremely discouraging and extremely unhelpful. This course is also the course that leads into our capstone projects but in this class we had no freedom in our research approaches and were only being taught extremely numerical, statistical, and quantitative methods with no mention of or real option for other very important research methods especially for those on the community development track.

The course materials on the professors private website were so disorganized and hard to follow. Having to look for an unclear and unorganized syllabus one place and then having to submit our assignment another place (Canvas) and then access dropbox on Sakai for feed back was extremely confusing and frustrating. Not having a clear syllabus document and one central course page on one platform made it extremely hard to keep track of class assignments and progress and to stay motivated as a person who needs structure to be successful. I have never experienced anything like this and it was extremely frustrating and stressful to navigate. It was such a shame this was the experience in this class as this is an extremely important course in our program and for our capstone.

Data Management Fall 2023

I wanted to be excited for this course, but he made it unapproachable and painful. He seemed to assume the answers to students' questions were obvious and would say "look at my notes" when students requested clarification. His notes were extremely minimal and often vague. I don't know if it occurs to him that the material he's teaching is not intuitive to people who haven't coded before. Frankly the course should not be offered to those who do not already have experience with python.

This instructor needs to learn basic pedagogy. I cannot overstate that. I never learned from a single lecture and I found office hours unhelpful as well. The instructor's communication skills and teaching skills in general make him difficult to approach. I eventually gave up on trying. Everything that I learned from this course I did on my own time by talking to graduate students in the computer science program. I have never left a review this negative before for an instructor. I am uncomfortable stating all of this, but I think it needs to be said. I would never have taken this course if I knew how it was run. I would actively discourage other students from taking this course unless it changes drastically.

Adam has been very dedicated to teaching the data science classes, but he seems indifferent to the needs of DPPA students. In addition to consulting with IDT, I recommend that Adam work with Bill Fitzgerald and other teaching mentors on the Camden Campus to address the issues highlighted above.

I would like to see Adam make a stronger contribution to teaching in his home department. Specifically, it would be helpful to have Adam take responsibility for the Regional and Economic Development course in the MS/PhD program and possibly one of the core PhD courses.

Service: Although Adam's service to the discipline and the Camden campus is good, I would like to see a stronger level of service to the department. Several DPPA faculty members have heavy service loads as program and center directors. As a result, we need Adam to take a stronger role in supporting the department. In his previous service on the Public Affairs committee with comprehensive exams, he submitted questions that had been posted online and could not be used. He appeared to put little time or effort into his work on the MS/PHD committee.

There are opportunities to take on a greater leadership role in several areas, including:

- Advising doctoral students
- Guiding dissertations and working collaboratively with other committee members
- Assisting the department with:
 - data dashboards
 - graduation rates for students,
 - data collection,
 - assisting with data from affiliated centers
- Workshops for PhD Students
- Data Mentoring

In his current role as Chair of the Awards and Events Committee, Adam needs to pay more attention to details. For example, in organizing the practice sessions for students participating in the UAA conference, he needs to clearly communicate the expectations and details of the practice sessions and coordinate multiple email reminders.

In the past, Adam has been enthusiastic about organizing brown bag presentations with graduate students. It would be helpful for him to re-engage with this practice. This aligns with his role as chair of the Awards & Events Committee. As noted above, he needs to take initiative in scheduling and communicating expectations/details of the events with faculty and graduate students.

Research: Although this is a good record, there is room for improvement in a variety of areas. In terms of research, Adam's research on cities would have more added value if he could speak to what leads to or causes unhappiness in cities. For example, is it density, diversity, or something else? What are the policy implications? In addition, it would be helpful to secure external grants and leverage internal grants/awards to fund his research, especially his Colombia project. It would also be helpful to have a clearer explanation of what his future research plans are.

9 Appendix: Paul's teaching evaluation and my response

Rutgers University-Camden
Department of Public Policy and Administration
Faculty Peer Evaluation of Classroom Teaching

Course:

- 56:219:521 DATA VISUALIZATION (dat sci)
- 56:824:728 DATA VISUALIZATION (soc sci/pub pol)
- 56:834:653 DATA VISUALIZATION (soc sci/pub pol)

Instructor: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn **Date Evaluated:** April 3, 2025

Note: Given the long time elapsed since the class observation, I supplemented my notes by watching the class video.

1. Subject of Class:

1) visualization techniques for data clustering, e.g. dendrograms and k-means scatterplots, 2) annotation of graphs using matplotlib, 3) “flipped classroom” to respond to student questions about a problem set.

2. Relevance of the subject to the course:

The content was appropriate to a course on data visualization, touching on important methods for representing clusters and relationships in data.

3. A. Was an assignment made: Yes _____ No ☒

Although no new assignment was introduced during the session, students appeared engaged with an assignment from the prior week and came prepared to discuss it.

B. Were students prepared: Yes ☒ No _____

4. Clarity of the ideas presented:

The description of the class as given to the students:

[apr3] clustering

a bit similar to previous scatterplots; clustering is about grouping / finding patterns, and very much data sciency!

we only scratch the surface here--just few popular vis for clustering;
i don't cover here the method, algorithms etc

Adam worked systematically through the material, alternating between code demonstrations in an online notebook and examples. The examples were presented clearly, but the presentation would have benefited from stronger substantive and conceptual framing. For example, the class could have explored more explicitly when to use a dendrogram versus a scatterplot with k-means clustering. For another, an “elbow plot” was presented as diagnostic for k-means clustering, but there was no explanation of what the plot represented, only that it tells you then ideal number of groups (based on what?). Without more grounding, the different types of visualizations are just black boxes.

While links to more in-depth discussion of the visualizations in relevant textbooks were provided, they lacked specific guidance (e.g., chapters or sections), which may make it difficult for students to locate the relevant material.

5. Manner of delivery:

Adam put students at ease and was very responsive to student questions. He made good use of examples, both simple examples using a small dataset followed by more complete examples using graphics from published papers.

6. Effective use of teaching aide(s), if they apply:

Rather than a whiteboard or PowerPoint slides, Adam used an online coding notebook, an environment for writing and executing code. This is an appropriate format given the material and the emphasis on coding. However, the notebook’s structure—one long, cumulative document covering several classes—made it difficult to follow at times, as his frequent scrolling up and down through the long document disrupted the flow. Segmenting the material into separate notebooks for each class or adding clearer section headings could improve clarity and pacing.

7. Student participation: The students were engaged throughout and asked appropriate questions. Adam had a good rapport with the students. When students sought deeper conceptual explanations (e.g., how clustering algorithms work), the responses could have gone beyond general descriptions to help students better understand the mechanics and assumptions of these techniques.

8: Other comments:

The syllabus and class notes would benefit from more careful organization and editing. Clearer structure, proofreading, and a consistent format would strengthen the professional presentation of the course materials and better reflect the high standards of our program.

More broadly, the course could be enhanced by integrating theoretical and design-oriented perspectives on data visualization—topics such as perception, cognition, and design principles. These form the intellectual foundation of the field and help students make informed decisions about how to represent data effectively and truthfully.

Adam’s course provides strong coding content and fosters an open, interactive learning

environment. The main opportunities for improvement lie in strengthening conceptual foundations, improving the organization and clarity of course materials, and ensuring that design and communication principles are integrated alongside technical skills. These adjustments would make the class more rigorous and balanced, aligning it more closely with the best practices in data visualization pedagogy. Without that, students may learn *how* to make various chart but not *why* certain choices communicate data more truthfully or effectively.

Paul A. Jorgensen

Visitor: _____

Date: 11/11/2025 Instructor: Bob Olin-Kay Date: _____
nov21 2025

Acceptance or comments:

The evaluation was helpful as it made me realize that my html bullet points didn't render and thus obscured readability; and it got me thinking about spending less time on code as AI takes over. Other than that the evaluation was unhelpful. I would like to raise several issues so that we can do better in the future.

Paul does not teach Python or data visualization. Neither does he use Python in his research. I was arguing to have someone else evaluate my teaching. I even found a replacement to do evaluation. Then I can't get the evaluation for 7 months (class was in April, I get evaluation in November) despite multiple emails and reminders. And then evaluation is mostly unhelpful as outlined below with my inline responses.

"the presentation would have benefited from stronger substantive and conceptual framing. "

It's a data visualization class, not math or algorithms class.

"an "elbow plot" was presented as diagnostic for k-means clustering, but there was no explanation of what the plot represented, only that it tells you then ideal number of groups (based on what?). Without more grounding, the different types of visualizations are just black boxes."

That's the whole point of the "elbow plot" to tell the number of groups. Again, it's a data visualization class, not math or algorithms class.

"While links to more in-depth discussion of the visualizations in relevant textbooks were provided, they lacked specific guidance (e.g., chapters or sections), which may make it difficult for students to locate the relevant material."

No. There is a reference to a specific chapter: "and especially machine learning ch: <https://jakevdp.github.io/PythonDataScienceHandbook/05.00-machine-learning.html>"

"the notebook's structure—one long, cumulative document covering several classes—made it difficult to follow at times, as his frequent scrolling up and down through the long document disrupted the flow. Segmenting the

material into separate notebooks for each class or adding clearer section headings could improve clarity and pacing."

There are not only section headings, but there are 3 levels of them: chapters, sections, and sub-sections (and I even police this in students' assignments—I take points off if students don't use sections).

"Clearer structure, proofreading, and a consistent format would strengthen the professional presentation of the course materials and better reflect the high standards of our program."

I was trying to discuss and get a sense of what Paul means here but I wasn't able to get detailed or specific information. As far as I can tell it's about writing style: Paul is traditional and formal. And I'm quite the opposite: modern, straightforward, and informal.

My materials have a clear structure and consistent format. I actually have a specific philosophy here to be straightforward and informal. I follow Zinnser's "On Writing Well: The Essential Guide to Mastering Nonfiction Writing and Effective Communication." For instance: "Never say anything in writing that you wouldn't comfortably say in conversation. If you're not a person who says "indeed" or "moreover," or who calls someone an individual ("he's a fine individual"), please don't write it." I was asking Paul for reference to his style, but I didn't get any.

I even wrote a paper on cluttered and ornamented grandiose prose in social science as compared to natural science: <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11192-012-0937-9>

So called social science "professional presentation" in writing can typically actually obscure meaning and communication. Again, following Zinnser, the goal should be simplicity and readability.

Per "high standards of our program"—i think my teaching has a good standard, e.g., my current students publish in good journals: https://theaok.github.io/okulicz_kozaryn_cv.pdf#page=6

And, what do we mean by "high standards of our program"? Is it formal traditional writing? Does such writing translate into desired outcomes, i.e. communication and learning? (especially in methods/coding classes). These are ever more relevant questions as we are increasingly over-burdened by information. Clarity, simplicity, and readability seem a way to go.

"More broadly, the course could be enhanced by integrating theoretical and design-oriented perspectives on data visualization—topics such as perception, cognition, and design principles. These form the intellectual foundation of the field and help students make informed decisions about how to represent data effectively and truthfully. Adam's course provides strong coding content and fosters an open, interactive learning environment. The main opportunities for improvement lie in strengthening conceptual foundations, improving the organization and clarity of course materials, and ensuring that design and communication principles are integrated alongside technical skills. These adjustments would make the class more rigorous and balanced, aligning it more closely with the best practices in data visualization pedagogy. Without that, students may learn how to make various chart but not why certain choices communicate data more truthfully or effectively."

These were covered in the course earlier. The class was geared towards the students, not towards the visitation, i.e. the visited Apr3 class was not self-contained, it did not include important elements included in other classes.

I did reach out to Paul to discuss, build bridges, and understand each other better. We had 2 discussions, somewhat helpful, but still I was not able to get enough details and specificity. I got a sense that it is time to wrap up, hence my lengthy response above. For the future, I am hoping we can agree to disagree and work out constructive compromises.

The evaluation was also helpful in a sense that I watched the class video and noted I could have had a little more eye contact and walk around more and be less on the monitor. But again as outlined above most of the evaluation is unhelpful--I hope in the future we can be more constructive. I am excited to discuss and collaborate on teaching. I think we could focus more on teaching.

Rev. 1/12

5.1.3 Gloria's (full professor in the department) comments on my promotion packet are highly likely (100% according to AI) to be AI-generated

Using <https://app.gptzero.me/> GPTZero AI Detection Model 4.6b: "We are highly confident this text was AI generated" "Chance this entire text is... AI 100%"

I have reviewed your dossier carefully, and I believe it would benefit from additional professional editing to strengthen the overall coherence and integration of your work across research, teaching, and service. Promotion committees often look closely for clear alignment among these areas, as well as evidence of how they collectively contribute meaningful value to the field, the classroom, the institution, and society more broadly.

At present, the narrative feels somewhat fragmented and does not fully convey the significance, purpose, and impact of your work. A stronger and more unified presentation could better articulate the story behind your contributions—specifically, who your work serves, why it matters, and how it advances scholarship, teaching, and service in meaningful ways.

I hope these comments are helpful and constructive as you continue refining the dossier. Best of luck with the process.

5.2 Research

5.2.1 Notes/Footnotes

It was already indicated on my CV (also sent to external reviewers): note: this book is excluded from the promotion packet (this is a popular science book): Happiness and Place: Cities v Nature. Why Life is Better Outside of the City? Palgrave Macmillan

I am collegial and collaborative—I've coauthored with over 20 authors (Scopus): <https://www.scopus.com/authid/detail.uri?authorId=23061538900#tab=co-authors>

5.2.2 Elaboration On My Research

5.2.3 Scientometrics

As per Google Scholar https://scholar.google.com/citations?hl=en&user=pz9RYloAAAAJ&view_op=list_works&sortby=pubdate: I have more than doubled my citations since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, from 163 to 353 in 2025.

According to Scopus <https://www.scopus.com/authid/detail.uri?authorId=23061538900>: I have had about 4 indexed publications per year since 2017, and also my citations more than doubled between 2017 and 2025.

According to <https://adscientificindex.com/> I am within the top 10% of RU scientists on H-Index (Recent) (220/2,364) <https://adscientificindex.com/scientist/adam-okulicz-kozaryn/1552726/>
(<https://adscientificindex.com/scientist/adam-okulicz-kozaryn/1552726/>)

5.3 Teaching

address low swb class eval bc on angela like cp paste all verbal stuff from 3 students incl 2 paraguay, and from my response to patrice; see notes in n.oorg in tenure/assoc-to-full

and add her transcript: keeps on getting Cs, not just me having issues with her

5.4 Letters from students

One highlight is that the skills learned in the classes work in the real world: “The classes I took with you are helping not only my scholarship, but my day job. Thank you [...] I greatly appreciate it.” and “subject:Received a Job Offer [...] I would like to thank you for all of the guidance and knowledge during all of your data-related courses the past several semesters to help me get to the point I am at today.” and “since graduating I have continued to pursue more projects in the coding world. Some analysis projects, business models, and even some fun web apps and game designs. I appreciate all the help and motivation you gave me in class as it helped me to really see what I can come up with from all of the useful tools, how to plan and build on projects, and skills gained from having you as my professor.”

And they work in academia, and students appreciate my approach and style: “I am reaching out to explore the possibility of having you as my graduate advisor. My experience in your Data Management course left a lasting impression on me and I appreciated your approach and teaching style. I believe your guidance would be invaluable in helping me navigate the academic journey towards finishing my doctoral degree.” and “This is Teacher Appreciation Week and I just wanted to take a moment to say thank you for all the hard work and dedication you put into teaching. Your passion for education has inspired and impacted me in so many ways. Your commitment to helping your students grow and learn is truly admirable. Thank you for all that you do!” and “Please know that I deeply appreciate everything you have done for me, and I recognize the many ways you have helped me grow as a scholar and, frankly, as an agentic person in general. I am truly grateful for you.”

And my classes might have even contributed to retention in the program: “I have learnt so much about my region is really unbelievable and I have enjoyed working with you a lot. So much, I am actually considering STAYING in the program because of you!”

“It was not an easy period for me, but your belief in me made a significant difference in helping me see it through. I recall one of your emails when you wrote, “...you have a passion for this, pursue it.” That statement has stayed with me. It reflected a genuine interest in my success, and I hope I am able to pay it forward.”

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Apr 15, 2026, 10:19
subject: Re: Request to pay open access APC from prof okulicz-kozaryn [260318-025834]

[...]Reflecting on this journey now, I just want to say that it was a great pleasure to work with you and to meet you Dr.Adam. But in this digital world, we will continue to communicate for sure and maybe do more work together in the future.

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Apr 23, 2026, 10:07
subject: Re: grant opportunity
mailed-by:

Dear Dr. Adam,

I hope you are doing well.

I wanted to take a moment to sincerely appreciate you for your support throughout my master's program. It was not an easy period for me, but your belief in me

I also wanted to share that I was selected as a finalist for the PhD in Global Urban Studies at Rutgers Newark, and I completed the interview process. However,

So you will definitely be seeing me again. :)

Thank you again for everything you've done to support me. I truly value your guidance

Warm regards

From:
Sent: Wednesday, April 8, 2026 12:19 AM

To: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <ao264@camden.rutgers.edu>
Subject: Fw: SEVIS Data Pull 4/6/2026 - Fall 2026

Dr. Adam,

I would be remiss if I didn't share that my day job includes working in Python all the time. The Director of the Office of International Students sends an Excel file each week that is essentially a data dump, and I've used all three of the classes I took with you to make sense of it each time. Without what I learned in your classes, it would just be a random Excel file - and I like Excel. This is just a small piece of it - I was emailing late into the night with her about ban lists and communication strategy, and that entire conversation would not have been possible without the visualizations.

I also create the attached HTML, which I share each week with my colleagues, and we've been relying on it for real decision-making. The HTML is about 85% for me - I regularly echo your point about adding notes to the data. That's what people talk about more than the visuals. They look at the charts, but they look forward to my notes.

I really appreciate everything I learned in your classes and your guidance in both my professional and academic work.

From:
Sent: Wednesday, January 21, 2026 11:21 AM
The classes I took with you are helping not only my scholarship, but my day job. Thank you. Again, thank you for sharing your knowledge and mentorship. I greatly appreciate it.

indep stu dec18 2025
Hi Professor,

I really appreciate it! Thank you so much!

Again, I am truly grateful to have been a student of yours and learn so much from you.

Have an amazing holiday!

J

2024-04-26 Fri gmail "Dissertation development credit issue and thank you"
Also - thank you. I realize that I have spent so much time this semester focusing on what I needed to do that I neglected to ever tell you how grateful I have been for our work together. I know that I can be a real pain in the ass, and you have definitely experienced that more than anyone else at Rutgers - six credits of courses with me and chairing my dissertation committee! Please know that I deeply appreciate everything you have done for me, and I recognize the many ways you have helped me grow as a scholar and, frankly, as an agentic person in general. I am truly grateful for you.

<2024-04-21 Sun> gmail: class "Completed sections"
"I have learnt so much about my region is really unbelievable and I have enjoyed working with you a lot. So much, I am actually considering STAYING in the program because of you!"

sp22 swb May 12 at 15:30pm
Hi, Dr. Adam. Here are the materials of my final work. I follow the instructions of JPAM style. The word document may not be as neat as the PDF one due to some technical issues. I am excited that it is my first quantitative paper, although there is still a long way from publication. Thank you so much for your help! Your classes have improved me a lot. I had never thought about being able to use these knowledges before taking your classes. Thank you!

Besides, could we keep working on this paper during this summer? It will be my great honor to make a publishment with you.

from:
to:Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date:Jun 25, 2018, 8:26 PM
subject:Received a Job Offer

Dr. Okulicz-Kozaryn,

I would like to thank you for all of the guidance and knowledge during all of your data-related courses the past several semesters to help me get to the point I am at today.

I was extended an offer with the Philadelphia School District as a Strategy Analyst with their Charter School Office. The office itself oversees Philadelphia's 84 charter schools (and 70k+ students). I will be doing a lot with the student level data in regard to performance/monitoring and helping with policy/research.

Thanks Again.

from:
to: "adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com" <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Oct 17, 2023
subject: Graduate Advisor Inquiry
mailed-by: em.rutgers.edu

Good Afternoon Professor Adam,

I hope this email finds you well! My name is xxx and I had the privilege of taking your Data Management course during the spring 2022 semester. I am currently enrolled in Rutgers-Camden's new PhD program in Prevention Science. I am reaching out to explore the possibility of having you as my graduate advisor. My experience in your Data Management course left a lasting impression on me and I appreciated your approach and teaching style. I believe your guidance would be invaluable in helping me navigate the academic journey towards finishing my doctoral degree. I am a part-time student with an expected completion date during the fall 2026 semester. My preliminary dissertation topic is research around the causal effects of a need-based aid program at Rutgers-New Brunswick using a quasi-experimental design such as regression discontinuity.

Please let me know if you prefer to discuss this over a Zoom call.

Best,

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: May 8, 2025
subject: Re: independent study

Hello Professor Okulicz-Kozaryn,

I have updated my github not only with my up to date notebook like I mentioned yesterday but I also uploaded this txt file as a writeup like you requested:
<https://github.com/>

If there is anything else you need from me, please let me know regarding the Independent Study.

I also want to say I am very happy to have taken your classes and had you to work with for this Independent study. I want to say the knowledge that you have helped me obtain along with the projects created are very much so appreciated.

I plan not only to continue research for this topic relating to music and spotify, but I am also going to take these concepts and principles for designing and working on projects with some other future endeavors as well.

And if you ever want to contact me for the future for any projects or know of any good opportunities for work or any other connections within the data science community you can contact me at:

I hope you have a good rest of your year and you enjoy your summer!

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Jan 25, 2026
subject: Re: independent study

Hello Professor Okulicz-Kozaryn,

This was an interesting read, I agree, it seems to be a similar idea to that one project I did for your class. Thanks for sending this along to me!

I may take some inspiration from this and add on to that previous project for continuing music analysis trends in the real world.

Also, I want to share that since graduating I have continued to pursue more projects in the coding world. Some analysis projects, business models, and even some fun web apps and game designs. I appreciate all the help and motivation you gave me in class as it helped me to really see what I can come up with from all of the useful tools, how to plan and build on projects, and skills gained from having you as my professor.

Thanks and hope all is well with you!

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
cc:
date: Dec 25, 2025
subject: Christmas Greetings
mailed-by: icloud.com

Hi Prof. Adam,

Wishing you a very Merry Christmas and a joyful holiday season. I hope you're enjoying a restful break and some well-deserved time.

I've been thinking back on my time in the PhD program and remain very grateful for your guidance and support along the way. I hope the new year brings you good health, energy, and many exciting moments ahead.

Warm holiday wishes,

from:
to: adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com
date: Nov 28, 2024
subject: Inquiry about Data Management Course
mailed-by: scarletmail.rutgers.edu

Hello Professor,

I hope this email finds you well. Happy Thanksgiving!

I am writing this email after seeing the Data Management course you will be teaching in Spring 2025. If possible, I would like to know more about the course curriculum. The subject is an area of interest for me, and I am enthusiastic about enrolling in the course. I have thoroughly enjoyed being in your GIS class and I look forward to learning more under your guidance.

Thank you for your time and consideration.

Regards,

from:
to: Kelly Esterly <kelly.esterly@rutgers.edu>,
Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Aug 5, 2025
subject: Capstone Project
mailed-by: scarletmail.rutgers.edu

Hello Prof. Adam,

I hope this email finds you well. I am reaching out to you for your guidance on my Capstone project in Fall '25. It was a great learning experience to take your classes. I look forward to working under your mentorship.

I am also having @Kelly Esterly on loop so she could issue the special code for the course

Looking forward to hearing from you. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Warm Regards,

from:
to: adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com
date: Oct 19, 2023
subject: Research opportunity Enquiry
mailed-by: scarletmail.rutgers.edu

Hello Professor ,

I'm xxx and I'm currently in your GIS class .It is great learning from you and I have been really enjoying studying subject.

I was wondering if there is any research /project opportunity to work with you ?
Is it possible to come visit you to talk regarding this at your convenience?

Thank you in advance
Regards ,

to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: May 2, 2023
subject: Thank you
mailed-by: gmail.com

Hi Dr. Adam,
This is Teacher Appreciation Week and I just wanted to take a moment to say thank you for all the hard work and dedication you put into teaching. Your passion for education has inspired and impacted me in so many ways. Your commitment to helping your students grow and learn is truly admirable. Thank you for all that you do!

Respectfully,

5.5 Service

Reviewing for journals: journals and counts are in the CV on p. 4: https://theaok.github.io/okulicz_kozaryn_cv.pdf#page=4

I want to highlight that I did all the service I was asked to do for the department.²⁶

DPPA could use some more democracy and refresh/update its structures.

Let's have more democracy, where non-full professors' voices are heard. Let's make sure people can grow, and pursue their own path.

We have these rigid structures both historical and current. Historical: someone decided probably 20-50 years ago we need certain class in core as requirements such as regional economic development, the person teaching that is long gone, the requirement still exists. Current: we have very rigid military like structure, there is one person at the top, then 3 more in a 'politbureau' and they are telling the rest what to do. Let's get rid of that and have democracy and capitalize on people's strengths and individual paths.

For instance, let's capitalize on my data science strength in teaching—we already started doing that and let's continue. I'm better fit to teach data science than regional economic development or quantitative methods that should be modernized and redesigned towards data science. I can make the case that data science (and Python, not Qgis or Stata) is the future and benefits our students. I am mindful of the fact that some DPPA students have struggled in the past, but now with AI that should not be a problem anymore.

²⁶Paul was unhappy with me once on his committee he kicked me out, then asked to join back in, but I did not join back in right away. Only later I told Patrice that if necessary I can join back in.